ROMAN KEY-CARD BLACKWOOD

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Since this is about slam bidding there may be some preliminary conventions which you do not play. In particular Jacoby 2NT forcing game raises, Major suit limit raises, and control-showing bids are used quite a bit.

ROMAN KEY-CARD BLACKWOOD SUMMARY

First a quick review of why we use Blackwood at all. It is not to help us get **TO** a makeable slam, it is to keep us **OUT** of unmakeable slams. Specifically Blackwood is so we don't make a fool of ourselves by bidding a slam when we are missing two Aces. And RKCBlackwood is an improvement to keep us from getting to a slam when we are missing the A K of trumps!

Ace-asking conventions often get abused and over-used because they are such a clever gimmick and they give the asker a great feeling of power. However, you should not ever ask a question if you don't know what to do with the answer. If that sounds cryptic, here are two specifics.

1. Do not use Blackwood when you have a void in your hand. If you do so then you won't be able to figure out if one of partner's Aces happened to be useless because it's in your void suit. Instead you should use control-showing bids when you have a void.
2. Do not use Blackwood when you have a suit with two quick losers. Unless partner's response shows you have all the Aces you won't be able to tell if you have two losers in the suit or not.

Key-Card Responses:

The foundation of RKCB is that instead of asking about the four Aces you will ask about the five Key Cards, the four Aces plus the trump King. It works pretty much like regular Blackwood, one partner says 4NT and the other gives a response that tells about the number of Key-Cards. Like this:

Responses to RKCB 4NT (1430 style)	
5♣	1 or 4 Key-Cards
5♦	0 or 3 Key-Cards
5♥	2 Key-Cards, WITHOUT the trump Queen
5♠	2 Key-Cards, WITH the trump Queen

A comment about that cryptic "1430 style".
What it means is that 1 or 4 is ♣s, 3 or 0 is ♦s.
There are two factions on this topic, the 1430 group and the 0314 group. Of course the 0314 group just reverse the ♣ and ♦ responses.

Some of the experts argue about which version is technically better, but it seems to me that it doesn't make a lot of difference. However the 1430 mode is a lot more popular so I chose it for this lesson,

and also for our own system. To help you remember 1430 all you have to do is remember that is the score for making a vulnerable Major suit slam.

Here are a few examples - in all cases ♥s are already agreed as trumps.

♠ 6 ♥ Q J 9 7 3 ♦ K Q 9 7 ♣ K 10 3

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♦	You have 0 Key-Cards.

♠ 6 ♥ Q J 9 7 3 ♦ K Q 9 7 ♣ A 10 3

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♣	You have 1 Key-Card, the ♣A.

♠ 6 ♥ K J 9 7 3 ♦ K Q 9 7 ♣ A 10 3

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♥	You have 2 Key-Cards (♣A, ♥K) without the Queen of trumps.

♠ 6 ♥ K Q 9 7 3 ♦ K Q 9 7 ♣ A 10 3

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♠	You have 2 Key-Cards (♣A, ♥K) with the Queen of trumps.

♠ 6 4 ♥ K 9 7 3 ♦ A Q 9 7 ♣ A 10 3

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♦	You have 3 Key-Cards, ♥K, ♦A, ♣A.

♠ 6 4 ♥ A K 7 3 ♦ A Q 9 7 ♣ A 10 3

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♣	You have 4 Key-Cards, ♥ A K, ♦A, ♣A.

What's Trumps?:

The trump King is a Key-Card and the trump Queen appears in some of the responses. So obviously you have to know what suit is trumps. In regular Blackwood this isn't necessary since you are only asked about Aces in general. But to use RKCB you absolutely **MUST** be able to identify a suit as trumps or the responses will be meaningless. Usually it is straightforward, but not always. So here are two rules to go by.

- If a suit has been agreed upon, then that suit is trump.
- If an agreement is not clear, then the last naturally bid suit is trump.

For example.

Pard	**You**	
1♦	1♠	This is pretty obvious that ♠s are trump.
3♠	4NT	

How about this one?

You	**Pard**	
1♦	1♠	Here there is no specific agreement.
3♥	4NT	Since ♥s were bid last, ♥s are trump.

Asking for Kings:

Just like in regular Blackwood, a 5NT bid asks for Kings. But remember that there are only three Kings. Since the King of trumps is counted as a Key-Card you don't also count it as a King.

Responses to RKCB 5NT	
6♣	0 Kings
6♦	1 King
6♥	2 Kings
6♠	3 Kings

By the way, if you ask for Kings you guarantee that your side has all 5 Key-Cards. This is equivalent to a 5NT bid in regular Blackwood which guarantees all 4 Aces.

The agreed suit is ♠s and this is your hand.
♠ A Q 7 6 ♥ 3 ♦ K Q 9 7 ♣ Q 7 6 3

Pard	You	
4NT	5♣	Showing **1** or 4 Key-Cards
5NT	6♦	Showing 1 King

The agreed suit is ♠s and this is your hand.
♠ K J 9 5 ♥ A K 7 3 ♦ A K ♣ J 10 3

Pard	You	
4NT	5♦	Showing 0 or **3** Key-Cards
5NT	6♥	Showing 2 Kings

The Queen Ask:

If you are just switching to RKCB you might want to defer using the Queen Ask feature until you are comfortable with the basic convention. The Queen Ask gets you more information but adds a layer of complexity.

Here's how it works.
If the response to 4NT is either 5♠ or 5♥, then you know whether Responder does/doesn't hold the Queen of trumps. It is just a little extra available information that sometimes comes in very handy. But a response of 5♣ or 5♦ tells you nothing about the trump Queen. So that's where the Queen Ask comes into play.

> After a 5♣ or 5♦ response the cheapest non-trump-suit bid asks for information about the trump Queen.

There are only four situations that can occur.
After a 5♣ response: a bid of 5♦ is the Queen Ask **UNLESS** ♦s are trump.

After a 5♣ response: a bid of 5♥ is the Queen Ask **IF** ♦s are trump.
After a 5♦ response: a bid of 5♥ is the Queen Ask **UNLESS** ♥s are trump.
After a 5♦ response: a bid of 5♠ is the Queen Ask **IF** ♥s are trump.

There are a couple of cautions to make right now.

- Obviously you cannot bid 5NT to ask for Kings if you are going to bid 5 of something else to ask for the Queen of trumps. So you have to choose which piece of information will help you the most.
- Using the Queen Ask may automatically get you up to the 6-level so be careful.

Responding to Queen Ask:

In short, a quick return to the trump suit denies the Queen, any other bid confirms the Queen.

Replies to Queen Ask	
Without the Queen	Bid trump suit at the cheapest level
With Queen	Bid 6 of the agreed trump suit if you have no outside King
With Queen	Bid the suit of your cheapest outside King if you can stay below 6 of your agreed suit
With Queen	Bid 5NT if your only outside King ranks above your agreed suit.

Here are some examples:

The agreed suit is ♠s and this is your hand.
♠ A Q 7 6 ♥ 3 ♦ K Q 9 7 ♣ Q 7 6 3

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♣	Showing **1** or 4 Key-Cards
5♦	6♦	Showing the trump Queen and the ♦K

The agreed suit is ♥s and this is your hand.
♠ 8 3 ♥ A J 9 7 ♦ K Q 9 7 ♣ K Q 6

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♣	Showing **1** or 4 Key-Cards
5♦	5♥	No trump Queen

The agreed suit is ♥s and this is your hand.
♠ K 3 ♥ Q J 9 7 ♦ Q J 9 7 ♣ A J 9

Pard	**You**	
4NT	5♣	Showing **1** or 4 Key-Cards
5♦	5♠	Trump Queen and ♠K

The agreed suit is ♥s and this is your hand.
♠ 9 3 ♥ K Q 9 7 ♦ A 7 5 ♣ A K 9 4

Pard	You	
4NT	5♦	Showing 0 or **3** Key-Cards
5♠	6♣	Trump Queen and ♣K

The agreed suit is ♥s and this is your hand.
♠ 9 3 ♥ K Q 9 7 ♦ A 7 5 ♣ A Q 9 4

Pard	You	
4NT	5♦	Showing 0 or **3** Key-Cards
5♠	6♥	Trump Queen, no outside King

The agreed suit is ♥s and this is your hand.
♠ K 3 ♥ K Q 9 7 ♦ A 7 5 ♣ A 9 5 4

Pard	You	
4NT	5♦	Showing 0 or **3** Key-Cards
5♠	5NT	Trump Queen and a King higher than ♥s

Responding with a Void:

This section is not specific to RKCB, it applies to standard Blackwood equally well. This just seemed like a good place to put it.

As long as there have been Ace-asking conventions there has been confusion about how to answer when you have a void. Should you respond as if the void were another Ace or not?

NOT!

It just puts too much strain on partner to think you have an Ace which turns out to be a void. In a worst case scenario he might decide to bid 7NT only to lose the first thirteen tricks!

Nonetheless there is a way for you to show that void.

In Response to a 4NT asking bid
6 of a suit ranking below trumps shows 1 or 3 Key-Cards and a void in the bid suit
6 of the trump suit shows 1 or 3 Key-cards and a void in an unspecified higher-ranking suit
5NT shows 2 or 4 Key-Cards and a void in an unspecified suit

Here are some examples:

The agreed suit is ♥s and this is your hand.
♠ K 9 8 6 3 ♥ A Q 9 7 ♦ -- ♣ Q 7 6 3

Pard	You	
4NT	6♦	Showing **1** or 3 Key-Cards and a ♦ void

The agreed suit is ♥s and this is your hand.
♠ -- ♥ A Q 9 7 ♦ K 9 8 6 3 ♣ Q 7 6 3

Pard	You	
4NT	6♥	Showing **1** or 3 Key-Cards and a void in a higher-ranking suit which is obviously ♠s

The agreed suit is ♥s and this is your hand.
♠ A 8 6 5 ♥ A K 7 4 ♦ A 9 8 6 3 ♣ --

Pard	You	
4NT	5NT	Showing 2 or **4** Key-Cards and a void in an unspecified suit

Remember that even if you decide to use standard Blackwood these void-showing responses still apply. Just wherever it says "Key-Cards" you read it as "Aces".

One last thing - a repeat of all the responses to RKCB 4NT in one table.

Responses to RKCB 4NT (1430 style)	
5♣	1 or 4 Key-Cards
5♦	0 or 3 Key-Cards
5♥	2 Key-Cards, WITHOUT the trump Queen
5♠	2 Key-Cards, WITH the trump Queen
5NT	even number of Key-Cards and a void in some suit
6*lower*	odd number of Key-Cards and a void in the lower-ranking bid suit
6*trump*	odd number of Key-Cards and a void in some higher-ranking suit

20 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 7♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥3

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥K

Board: 3
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦10

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦5

Board: 5
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦3

Board 1
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ K Q J 9 6 5 ♥ A K ♦ 8 7 5 ♣ A 5	
♠ 7 ♥ J 7 6 ♦ K 9 6 3 2 ♣ 7 6 4 3		♠ 2 ♥ 9 5 3 2 ♦ A Q J 10 4 ♣ Q 9 8
	♠ A 10 8 4 3 ♥ Q 10 8 4 ♦ — ♣ K J 10 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♠	Pass	4♦
Pass	4NT	Pass	6♦
Pass	7♠		
All Pass			

7♠ by North
Lead: ♥3

Partner's 4♦ bid is a Splinter Bid. It shows opening hand strength, at least 4-card ♠ support, and a singleton or void in ♦s.

Normally you would not ask for Key-Cards with this ♦ holding. But since you know partner has at most a singleton, and that it is not the singleton ♦A, you are safe to do so. You say 4NT, partner replies 6♦. What next?

WOW! Partner has one Key-Card and a ♦ void. So the Key-Card is the ♠A. You don't know what the rest of partner's hand is, but he can surely take care of that small ♣. You bid 7♠.

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ J 9 6 2 ♥ J 9 5 3 ♦ 5 2 ♣ 4 3 2	
♠ A Q 5 ♥ 4 ♦ A K 10 8 6 3 ♣ A K Q	N W E S	♠ K 8 7 ♥ A 10 6 ♦ Q 9 7 4 ♣ J 10 8
	♠ 10 4 3 ♥ K Q 8 7 2 ♦ J ♣ 9 7 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2♣	Pass	2NT	Pass
3♦	Pass	4♦	Pass
4NT[1]	Pass	5♣[2]	Pass
5♥	Pass	5♠	Pass
7NT			
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

7NT by East
Lead: ♥K

Your 2NT response shows 8+ points, with no 5-card biddable suit.

You support the ♦s and partner bids 4NT. What is your next bid?

With ♦s as trump you have 1 Key-Card, the ♥A. You answer 5♣ and partner bids 5♥. What is your bid?

This is the Queen Ask, wanting to know if you hold the ♦Q. Since you do have it you should bid a suit in which you hold a King. So you bid 5♠. That spurred partner on - he was fishing for 7♦ but when you told him you had the ♦Q, ♥A and ♠K he was able to bid 7NT.

Board 3
West Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ Q 8 ♥ A J 9 7 ♦ K Q J ♣ A K Q 6	
♠ 10 9 7 4 3 ♥ 4 ♦ 10 9 6 2 ♣ 9 4 3		♠ A K J 6 5 2 ♥ 5 ♦ A 8 7 4 ♣ 7 5
	♠ — ♥ K Q 10 8 6 3 2 ♦ 5 3 ♣ J 10 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	3♠
Pass	4NT	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

6♥ by South
Lead: ♦10

Partner's 2♥ is a positive response, 8+ points with a 5+ card suit.

Even though it is tempting, bidding RKCB now would be a mistake because of your doubleton ♠ loser. Instead just support the ♥s. Partner cannot pass, you both know you are forced to game. In fact, partner bids 3♠.

Partner promises first round ♠ control so NOW you can bid RCKB. When you bid 4NT partner answers 6♥. This shows 1 Key-Card and a void in a suit higher than ♥s. Knowing you are missing either the ♦A or ♥K you pass.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 6 ♥ Q 4 3 ♦ Q J 7 5 2 ♣ Q J 8 3	
♠ A Q J 8 5 4 3 ♥ 7 ♦ A K 4 ♣ A K		♠ K 10 7 2 ♥ A K 8 6 5 ♦ 8 3 ♣ 6 4
	♠ 9 ♥ J 10 9 2 ♦ 10 9 6 ♣ 10 9 7 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2♣	Pass	2♥	Pass
2♠	Pass	3♠	Pass
4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]	Pass
5NT[3]	Pass	6♦	Pass
7NT			
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards without the trump queen
3. asks for kings

7NT by West
Lead: ♦5

Your 2♥ response shows 8+ points, with at least 5 ♥s.

Your hand is looking better and better. You already gave a positive response so you know you are forced to game. It is better to keep the bidding low to allow more investigating room so you bid 3♠. Partner bids 4NT. What is your response?

With ♠s agreed as trumps you have two Key-Cards, the ♠K and the ♥A. With no trump Queen you respond 5♥. Partner now says 5NT. What do you reply?

Partner is asking for Kings and you have just 1, the ♥K. Remember, the ♠K is not a King, it is a Key-Card which you have already counted. So you bid 6♦. Partner counts 13 tricks and bids 7NT.

Board 5
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K 9 6 5 4 ♥ K Q 6 ♦ K Q J 2 ♣ —	
♠ 8 2 ♥ J 9 4 2 ♦ A 7 ♣ 9 8 4 3 2		♠ 10 ♥ 10 7 5 3 ♦ 9 5 3 ♣ A Q 10 7 6
	♠ Q J 7 3 ♥ A 8 ♦ 10 8 6 4 ♣ K J 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♣	Pass	4♥
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by North
Lead: ♦3

Partner's 3♠ is a limit raise, 11-12 points and good ♠ support.

What you DO NOT say next is 4NT. If partner answered 1 Key-Card you would not know what to do. If he has a red Ace you can make slam, but if his one Key-Card were the ♣A you couldn't. Instead you make a control-showing bid of 4♣, promising first round control. Partner obliges you by bidding 4♥. What is your next bid?

Partner's bidding is like the Sherlock Holmes tale Silver Blaze, about the dog that didn't bark. Partner's ♥ bid shows that he **DOES** have the ♥A, but equally important it shows that he **DOES NOT** have the ♦A. So you know you don't have a ♥ loser but do have a ♦ loser. You bid 6♠.